

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 21

MARYLAND

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Maryland's family courts and child-welfare system.

59

MARYLAND FAMILIES ON RECORD · 106 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
OCTOBER 19, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
24 OF 24

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MARYLAND AT A GLANCE.

Across 59 Maryland families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST	WENT PRO SE
106	**$368,500**	**18**	**45.8%**
58 of 59 families reported child counts	median across 16 families reporting 3+ categories	of parenting time	27 of 59 who answered; 20 of 59 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
59	1.8	58 of 59	24

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Maryland families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

02 THE COST OF MARYLAND FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	43	$26,000	$70,698	$3,040,000
Lost Wages	24	$15,500	$178,396	$4,281,500
Other Court Fees	14	$3,000	$3,844	$53,820
Therapy / Evaluations	14	$1,350	$5,979	$83,700
Reunification Services	14	$0	$664	$9,300
GAL Fees	15	$2,000	$6,033	$90,500
Asset Loss [1]	18	$62,500	—	—
Median Family Burden (16 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$368,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($62,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



03 WHO IS REPORTING · MARYLAND

Most families documenting in Maryland are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	27	47%
Not provided	12	21%
Case closed: within last 2 years	7	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	6	10%
Active case: progress being made	4	7%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only	32	54%
Both Family Court and CPS	21	36%
Unknown	4	7%
CPS Only	2	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	24	42%
3 – 5 years	9	16%
5 – 10 years	8	14%
6 months – 1 year	7	12%
Over 10 years	5	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only	16	27%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access	15	25%
50/50 Joint	13	22%
Full Custody	7	12%
Children in Foster Care	3	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Baltimore	6	14%
Frederick	3	7%
Howard	3	7%
Washington	3	7%
Baltimore City	2	5%
Anne Arundel	2	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	23	40%
Other	7	12%
Other: (Short answer)	7	12%
High Conflict Divorce	6	10%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	5	9%

04 PARENT VOICES — MARYLAND

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Maryland comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!*
>
> — RACHEL

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony [...]

— MARYLAND PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM MARYLAND

The system came in and ripped my daughter out of my arms with no due process and created years of severe, dibilitating separation anxiety for her.

— NICOLE

CPS has filed to terminate my rights completely for my two older children. I was never informed of the 15-22 months "timeframe" they lied on every single court report and never acknowledged any progress I made

— HANNAH

CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of [...]

— TYLER

My husband and abuser used a false protective order and manipulated my son to vouch for him and then turn, got me removed from the marital Home and I lost our 4 children

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Granddaughter said father was abusing her. Rape kit and forensic nurses confirmed this. Judge ordered child back to abuser. Child was only 3.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has destroyed me and my children. They gave primary custody to an abuser, alcoholic and illicit drug maker and abuser. My children are nose diving in destruction. None of this is in their best interest.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *This system has ruined mine and my husband's life ruined my family. The CPS worker is a witch and ruins peoples lives.*
>
> — ALINA

The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They are taking a dedicated full-time mother almost completely away from her children. And gave them to my ex-husband who was never present.

— JESSICA

Ex and wife never wanted the children. They just didn't want me to have the children. Covert-insidious form of abuse. Children aged out of the system. Ex hasn't contacted children in months/years. Adult children are still traumatized and in therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Have destroyed my faith in the country live and fought and killed for. I lost my children, my life financial I'm struggling and I don't wish to happen to anyone.

— ABU

Broke mother and dimmed three childrens lights spirits and souls causing severe distrust and perpetual fear of abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I entered family court expecting protection and fairness, believing evidence, truth, and due process mattered. Instead, my family was damaged over years through ignored evidence, unfinished hearings, and baseless mental-health narratives that caused lasting pain, trauma, and [...]

— JAIME

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Separated my two minor children. Placed my daughter in the arms of an abuser. Missed Drs. Appointments for chronically ill daughter and then stated they are just routine appointments when I told the court her dad was not taking her while in his custody*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is been absolutely devastating for me but terroristically traumatizingfir my intentionally parented baby who's world has been turned upside down for profit. I am beyond mortified but determined to correct my mistakes and rescue my Baby Girl

— NIKKI

It's taken away our ability to advocate and protect our children. They're in danger everyday and we can't do anything to help them. No matter how we fight to protect them it's twisted as abuse towards the ex partner....never do they look at the abuse towards the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has affected every area of my life-career, ability to protect my child and myself from narcissistic & financial abuse, and the ability to fully move forward with life.

— JASMINE

My daughter has had the brunt of the damage, with severe behavioral, emotional, and psychological abuse by the opposite party, schools, daycare personnel, friends and family of the opposing side. I've seen experienced total mental and emotional abuse with ongoing financial abuse.

— GRAYSON

A Citizenry without Judicial integrity within its courts, isn't free. Judicial Integrity is the last line of defense for a free nation.

— JEANNETTE

This system treated her word as fact and her lies as evidence. Treated me as a criminal

— WILL

They gave my daughter to her molester and he isn't even her biological father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Stunted my son's development as an autistic child and while the court enabled my abusers crack cocaine addiction. Litigation abuse all fueled by his mother's inheritance. I was DRUGGED, RAPED, financially abused, SEX TRAFFICKED and SILENCED. I'm a surrogate and free child care [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The court system has capitalized on my situation and benefited finanicially at the cost of my child's emotional health.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

Left child in narcissists care, caused severe mental damage to child by completely alienating one parent

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Put my child in the hands of a sexual predator, completely dismissing his repeated disclosures and cries for help.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broken my soul Made me sick I lost so much

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

To the mothers suffering from post parttum dealing with the threat of having your infant taken is inhumane to all mothers but especially the ones in this delicate time contact me if need be I dont mind I would love to expose this corruption, my instagram is @blissfullyblunt I am [...]

— REBECCA

It has failed me. Not allowing me to be a father

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has allowed my children's father's mother to intervene on his behalf of ONE of our three children, his entire eight years of existence. While trusting my other two children to be with me full-time, they have allowed this woman to abuse, my son, myself and my entire [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered it entirely

— SHERRI

The system has empowered my ex-wife with control, removed my son from my life, removed my daughter from my life. It was beaten me mentally as I just want to love my kids and give them the best things that I can but am no longer able to due to financial burden of using a lawyer [...]

— JOHN

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *My family and their associates all assisted in attempted murder, and kidnapping of my child. There is trafficking and other crimes involved. Several counties and the FBI refused assistance when reported repeatedly for over a year. They stole my home my child and my finances.*
>
> — KACIE

This system has shown me that it favors a mother no matter what. Despite overwhelming evidence to prove my ex-wife was lying and abusing the system to "win" the divorce I lost custody of my kids, I was kicked out of my house several times, I have lost about 20 months of time [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This parent coordinator routinely violates state law and constitutional law by requiring meetings with zero agenda and then engaging and attempting to enforce decisions about child's diet, friends, education, third parties, religion, medical care, and she attends child therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

After having primary custody for over 8 years and being the primary caregiver for 14 years. the court decided to change custody in because of a military relocation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This process has broken our hearts in ways words can hardly describe, forcing our family to live through years of pain, fear, uncertainty, and separation from a child we love deeply. Every missed birthday, holiday, milestone, hug, and bedtime story is time we can never get back [...]

— CALYNN

This was a well laid plan of attack! They hid evidence and dismissed anyone who told the truth and didn't conform to their plot against me. They would all sit in the courtroom with my ex discussing lunch plans and laughing while I stood in the hall frantically emailing law [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

39 Maryland parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 39 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MARYLAND

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Maryland families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!
>
> — RACHEL

> Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony conviction for Aggravated animal creulty, 2nd degree assault against mother (me), and refuses to believe the children when they disclose abuse that was reported by their pediatrician with CPS and the police investigating and almost removed the children from mother. The whole system is rigged and they don't care about the children.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

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> — NICOLE

> CPS has filed to terminate my rights completely for my two older children. I was never informed of the 15-22 months "timeframe" they lied on every single court report and never acknowledged any progress I made
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> — HANNAH

> CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of family preservation while breastfeeding. Refused to place my 3 kids with family instead of fosters for two weeks. If it wasn't for the twins foster parent we would still be so far behind.
>
> — TYLER

> My husband and abuser used a false protective order and manipulated my son to vouch for him and then turn, got me removed from the marital Home and I lost our 4 children
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— ALINA

The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because of being a male in a corrupt law enforcement and court systems that sees men as guilty first without any evidence and that doesn't believe women can be abusers and refuses to prosecute even with evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— JESSICA

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— JAIME

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— KACIE

This system has shown me that it favors a mother no matter what. Despite overwhelming evidence to prove my ex-wife was lying and abusing the system to "win" the divorce I lost custody of my kids, I was kicked out of my house several times, I have lost about 20 months of time with my kids that I was heavily involved with for their entire lives as a stay-at-home dad for many years of their lives. I was crushed and due to my ex-wife's poor choices our kids suffered more than anybody ever did. I did everything to protect my kids but the "silver bullet" hit hard. I tried everything in my power to ensure they were kept out and to try and finalize the divorce amicably but my ex thought she could lie to the courts so I wouldn't get her retirement. Total between both parties spent was well over $100k which could have gone towards the kids and many other things. I was jailed for 70 days for allegedly waving to my 3 year old daughter. I was facing 5 years for showing up to watch my 16 year old daughter play volleyball on her 16th birthday. I did not contact her and the school was not on the list of places not to go, but I was arrested and am now on probation for 3 years for simply going to my daughters volleyball game at a location that I was freely allowed to be at.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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> — CALYNN

> This was a well laid plan of attack! They hid evidence and dismissed anyone who told the truth and didn't conform to their plot against me. They would all sit in the courtroom with my ex discussing lunch plans and laughing while I stood in the hall frantically emailing law makers and government officials trying to get help!
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39 full approved Maryland comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Maryland report comes from Maryland respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Maryland — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 59 Maryland families reporting here are not the universe of Maryland families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – October 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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